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Endgames and Conversion From the Repertoire

Carry structural advantages into endings and neutralize dynamic compensation

COURSE BOOK

20 focused chapters - model positions - decision rules - retrieval practice

Designed to change what you notice, calculate, remember, and do at the board.

How to Use This Course

ONE CHAPTER, FOUR PASSES

1. Read the position without moving pieces. 2. State your plan and the opponent's counterplay. 3. Study the decision rules. 4. Close the book and reconstruct the position from memory.

RETRIEVAL SCHEDULE

Review the chapter the next day, one week later, and after a game that reaches a similar structure. Retrieval is more valuable than rereading.

BOARD ROUTINE

Opponent's threat - forcing moves - loose pieces - worst piece - central break - best reply - choose and stop.

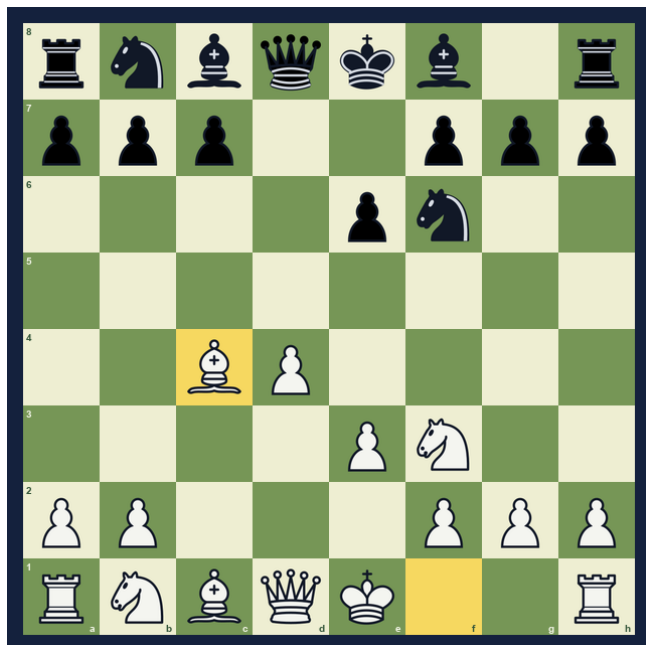
The course book explains each model position. The separate workbook forces recall, prediction, and self-scoring. Use the book first, then attempt the matching workbook page without looking back.

Engine evaluations are intentionally not the lesson. The aim is to store human decision rules that remain useful when the exact move order changes.

Course Map

MODULE	CHAPTERS
ENDGAMES AND CONVERSION	20

01. Activate the King



ENDGAMES AND CONVERSION

READ THE POSITION

After queens leave, king activity becomes a concrete piece advantage.

PRIMARY PLAN

Calculate the king route before pushing pawns.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 dxc4 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. e3 e6 5. Bxc4

MEMORY RULE

In endings, the king is a fighting piece.

01. Decision Framework

Activate the King

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only after naming the favorable feature that survives the recapture.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Forecast the king activity, pawn targets, files, majorities, and minor-piece quality that survive simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible choices; move efficiently only in a position you truly recognize.

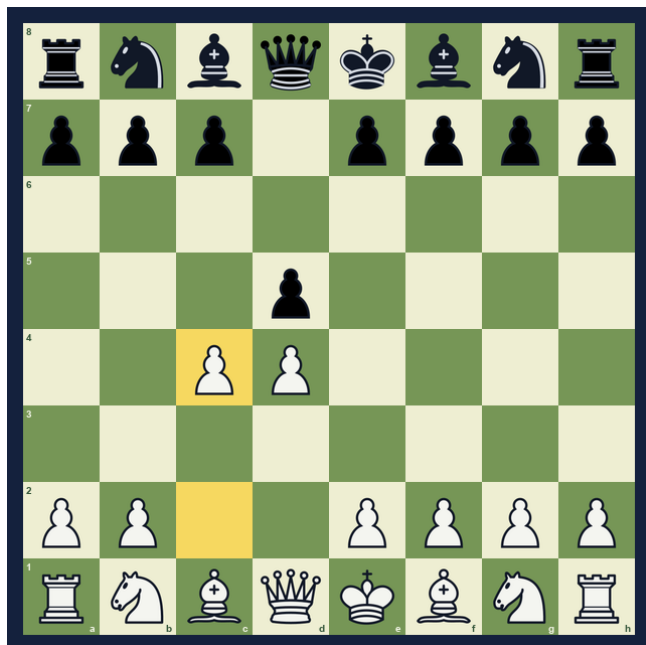
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: In endings, the king is a fighting piece.

02. Rook Activity Before Pawns



ENDGAMES AND CONVERSION

READ THE POSITION

An active rook can compensate for a pawn and restrict the enemy king.

PRIMARY PLAN

Seek files, checks, and entry squares before collecting material.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4

MEMORY RULE

Rooks need activity more than pawn defense.

02. Decision Framework

Rook Activity Before Pawns

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only after naming the favorable feature that survives the recapture.
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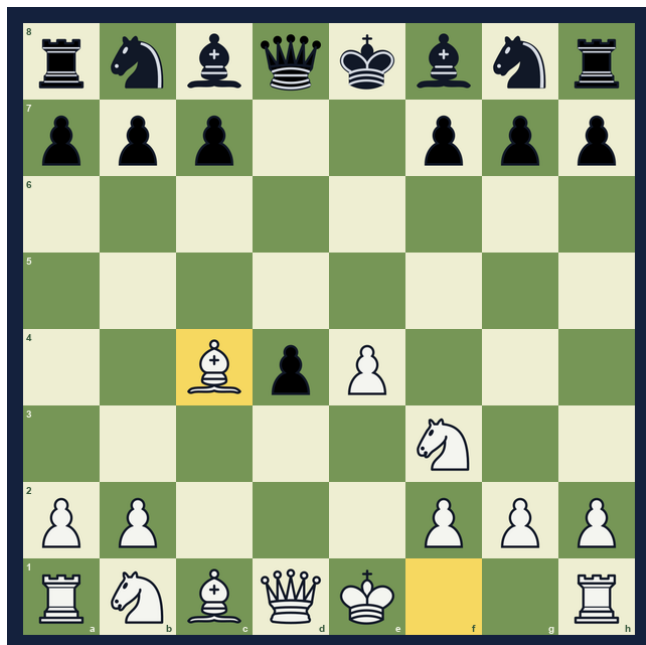
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5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Rooks need activity more than pawn defense.

03. Carlsbad Endgames



ENDGAMES AND CONVERSION

READ THE POSITION

The minority attack can leave a permanent c6 target even after pieces are exchanged.

PRIMARY PLAN

Keep enough pieces to attack the weakness and activate the king.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE 1. d4 d5 2. c4 dxc4 3. e4 e5 4. Nf3 exd4 5. Bxc4

MEMORY RULE

The structural target should survive the trade.

03. Decision Framework

Carlsbad Endgames

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only after naming the favorable feature that survives the recapture.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Forecast the king activity, pawn targets, files, majorities, and minor-piece quality that survive simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible choices; move efficiently only in a position you truly recognize.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: The structural target should survive the trade.

04. IQP Endgames



ENDGAMES AND CONVERSION

READ THE POSITION

An isolated pawn often loses its dynamic value after pieces disappear.

PRIMARY PLAN

Trade into the ending only when activity or a passed-pawn break remains.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 dxc4 3. Nf3 a6 4. e3 b5 5. a4 Bb7 6. axb5 axb5 7. Rxa8 Bxa8

MEMORY RULE

The IQP wants pieces; the defender wants exchanges.

04. Decision Framework

IQP Endgames

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only after naming the favorable feature that survives the recapture.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Forecast the king activity, pawn targets, files, majorities, and minor-piece quality that survive simplification.
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ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: The IQP wants pieces; the defender wants exchanges.

05. Hanging-Pawn Endgames



ENDGAMES AND CONVERSION

READ THE POSITION

Connected pawns can create a passer or become two fixed weaknesses.

PRIMARY PLAN

Advance at the moment the resulting passer is supported.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 dxc4 3. Nf3 c5 4. e3 cxd4 5. exd4 Nf6 6. Bxc4

MEMORY RULE

Do not freeze both pawns without compensation.

05. Decision Framework

Hanging-Pawn Endgames

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only after naming the favorable feature that survives the recapture.
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CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible choices; move efficiently only in a position you truly recognize.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
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3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Do not freeze both pawns without compensation.

06. QGA Queenless Positions



ENDGAMES AND CONVERSION

READ THE POSITION

Open files and active kings matter more than the opening's temporary pawn sacrifice.

PRIMARY PLAN

Recover material while preserving rook activity and central control.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 dxc4 3. Nf3 a6 4. e3 b5 5. a4 Bb7 6. axb5 axb5 7. Rxa8 Bxa8

MEMORY RULE

An extra tempo can outweigh a pawn in an open ending.

06. Decision Framework

QGA Queenless Positions

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only after naming the favorable feature that survives the recapture.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Forecast the king activity, pawn targets, files, majorities, and minor-piece quality that survive simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible choices; move efficiently only in a position you truly recognize.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: An extra tempo can outweigh a pawn in an open ending.

07. Use the Bishop Pair



ENDGAMES AND CONVERSION

READ THE POSITION

Two bishops control both color complexes and support play on both wings.

PRIMARY PLAN

Open the position and avoid exchanging the more useful bishop without a concrete gain.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Nf3 c6 6. Bg5 Be7 7. Qc2 O-O 8. e3 Nbd7 9. Bd3 Re8 10. O-O

MEMORY RULE

The bishop pair grows with open lines.

07. Decision Framework

Use the Bishop Pair

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only after naming the favorable feature that survives the recapture.
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ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: The bishop pair grows with open lines.

08. Opposite-Colored Bishops



ENDGAMES AND CONVERSION

READ THE POSITION

They can create drawing fortresses in endings and stronger attacks with queens present.

PRIMARY PLAN

Identify whether kings or passed pawns are the real target.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Nf3 c6 6. Bg5 Be7 7. Qc2 O-O 8. e3 Nbd7 9. Bd3 Re8 10. O-O

MEMORY RULE

Opposite bishops change value with the major pieces.

08. Decision Framework

Opposite-Colored Bishops

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
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4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Opposite bishops change value with the major pieces.

09. Knight Outposts



ENDGAMES AND CONVERSION

READ THE POSITION

A knight on a protected square can dominate a fixed pawn structure.

PRIMARY PLAN

Preserve the supporting pawn and remove the knight's exchange opponent.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bg5 Be7 6. e3 O-O 7. Bd3 Nbd7 8. Qc2 Re8 9. Nge2 Nf8 10. O-O

MEMORY RULE

An outpost is an endgame asset when it cannot be challenged.

09. Decision Framework

Knight Outposts

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only after naming the favorable feature that survives the recapture.
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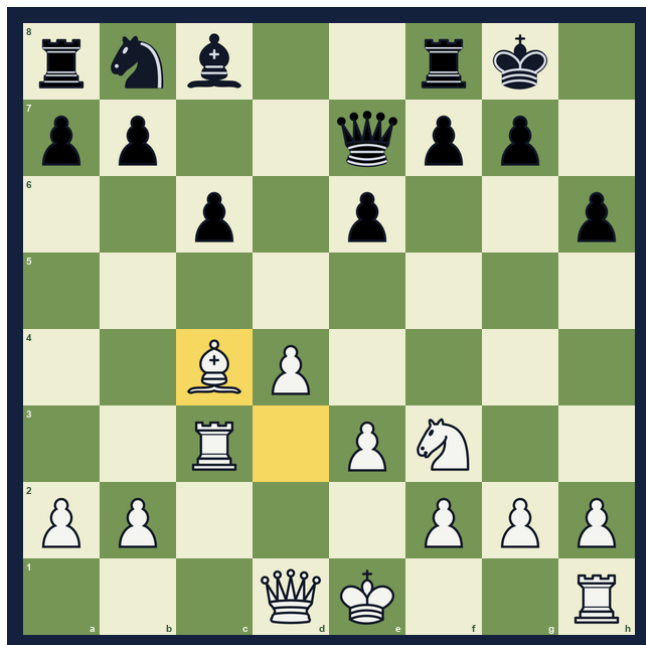
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5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: An outpost is an endgame asset when it cannot be challenged.

10. Create a Passed Pawn



ENDGAMES AND CONVERSION

READ THE POSITION

A majority matters when it can create a passer without losing a race elsewhere.

PRIMARY PLAN

Calculate both wings before advancing the majority.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 Be7 5. e3 O-O 6. Nf3 h6 7. Bh4 Ne4 8. Bxe7 Qxe7 9. Rc1 c6 10. Bd3 Nxc3 11. Rxc3 dxc4 12. Bxc4

MEMORY RULE

A passer is strongest when it diverts the king.

10. Decision Framework

Create a Passed Pawn

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only after naming the favorable feature that survives the recapture.
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4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: A passer is strongest when it diverts the king.

11. Queenside Majority



ENDGAMES AND CONVERSION

READ THE POSITION

Many d4-c4 structures leave White with queenside space or an extra pawn.

PRIMARY PLAN

Fix targets, activate the king, and create the passer only when counterplay is controlled.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Nf3 Be7 5. Bf4 O-O 6. e3 c5 7. dxc5 Bxc5 8. Qc2 Nc6 9. Rd1 Qa5 10. a3

MEMORY RULE

A majority is potential until it produces a passer.

11. Decision Framework

Queenside Majority

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only after naming the favorable feature that survives the recapture.
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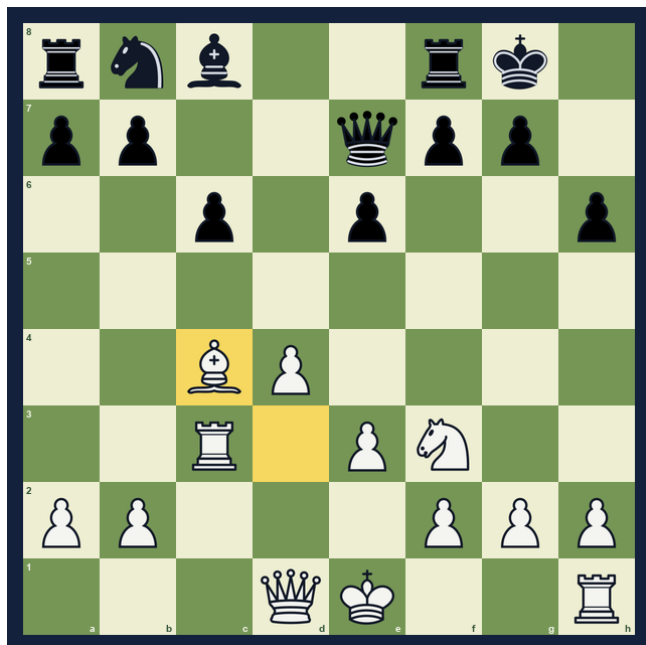
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3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: A majority is potential until it produces a passer.

12. Benko Material Versus Activity



ENDGAMES AND CONVERSION

READ THE POSITION

White may remain a pawn ahead but Black's rooks can stay active.

PRIMARY PLAN

Return material if it wins files, trades rooks, or activates the king.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 Be7 5. e3 O-O 6. Nf3 h6 7. Bh4 Ne4 8. Bxe7 Qxe7 9. Rc1 c6 10. Bd3 Nxc3 11. Rxc3 dxc4 12. Bxc4

MEMORY RULE

Convert the pawn by neutralizing activity.

12. Decision Framework

Benko Material Versus Activity

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only after naming the favorable feature that survives the recapture.
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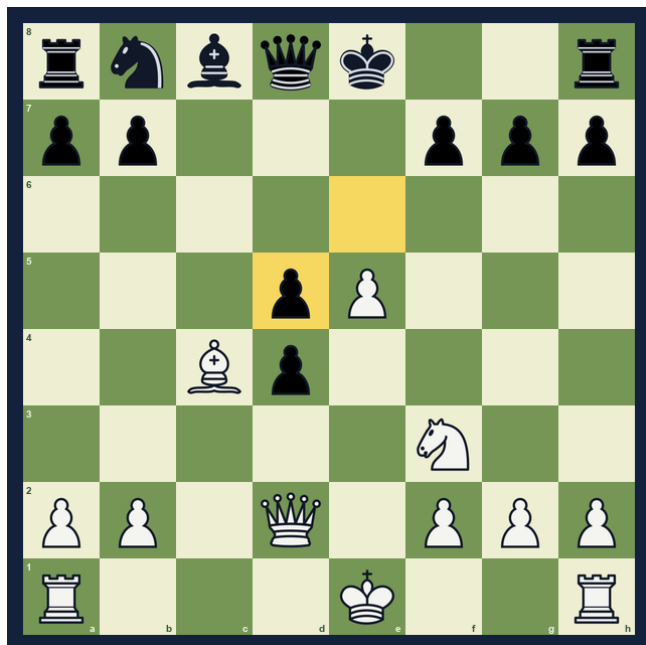
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3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Convert the pawn by neutralizing activity.

13. King's Indian Transition



ENDGAMES AND CONVERSION

READ THE POSITION

A closed kingside attack can transform into a queenless space ending.

PRIMARY PLAN

Reevaluate pawn weaknesses after the attacking pieces leave.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Nf3 dxc4 5. e4 Bb4 6. e5 Nd5 7. Bd2 c5 8. Bxc4 cxd4 9. Nxd5 Bxd2+ 10. Qxd2 exd5

MEMORY RULE

The middlegame plan may disappear with the queens.

13. Decision Framework

King's Indian Transition

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
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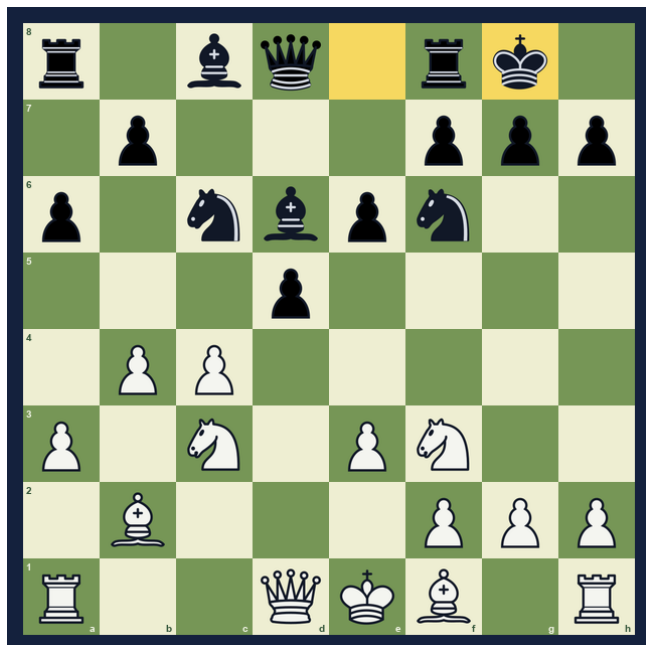
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4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: The middlegame plan may disappear with the queens.

14. Dutch Weak Squares



ENDGAMES AND CONVERSION

READ THE POSITION

Dark-square weaknesses around Black's king can remain after queens are traded.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use the king and minor pieces to occupy permanent squares.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 c5 4. e3 Nf6 5. Nf3 Nc6 6. a3 a6 7. dxc5 Bxc5 8. b4 Bd6 9. Bb2 O-O

MEMORY RULE

A weak square survives when no pawn can challenge it.

14. Decision Framework

Dutch Weak Squares

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only after naming the favorable feature that survives the recapture.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Forecast the king activity, pawn targets, files, majorities, and minor-piece quality that survive simplification.
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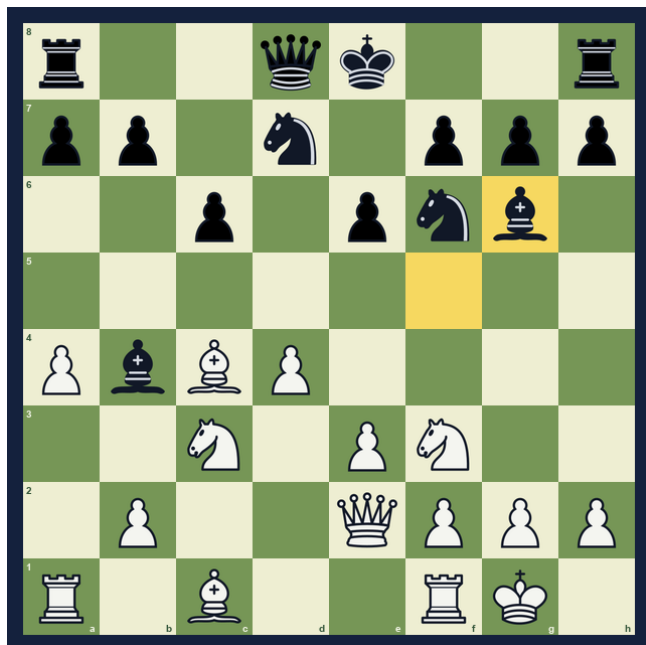
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4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: A weak square survives when no pawn can challenge it.

15. When to Trade Queens



ENDGAMES AND CONVERSION

READ THE POSITION

Queen trades reduce king danger but can also remove the initiative.

PRIMARY PLAN

Describe the resulting king activity, pawn structure, and minor pieces first.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 dxc4 5. a4 Bf5 6. e3 e6 7. Bxc4 Bb4 8. O-O Nbd7 9. Qe2 Bg6

MEMORY RULE

Trade queens for a favorable ending, not for relief.

15. Decision Framework

When to Trade Queens

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only after naming the favorable feature that survives the recapture.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Forecast the king activity, pawn targets, files, majorities, and minor-piece quality that survive simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible choices; move efficiently only in a position you truly recognize.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Trade queens for a favorable ending, not for relief.

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The correct exchange depends on outposts, pawn colors, and targets.

Compare the best square and future job of every remaining minor piece.

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 a6 5. c5 Bf5 6. Bf4 Nbd7 7. e3 Nh5 8. Bg5 h6 9. Bh4 g5 10. Bg3 Nxg3 11. hxg3 Bg7

Trade the opponent's useful piece, not merely an equal-value piece.

16. Decision Framework

Which Minor Piece to Trade

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only after naming the favorable feature that survives the recapture.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Forecast the king activity, pawn targets, files, majorities, and minor-piece quality that survive simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible choices; move efficiently only in a position you truly recognize.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Trade the opponent's useful piece, not merely an equal-value piece.

17. Rook Trade Decisions



ENDGAMES AND CONVERSION

READ THE POSITION

Trading one pair of rooks can reduce counterplay; trading all rooks can erase winning chances.

PRIMARY PLAN

Forecast the pawn ending and remaining entry squares.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 dxc4 4. e3 b5 5. a4 Bb7 6. b3 cxb3 7. Qxb3 a6 8. Ba3 Nf6

MEMORY RULE

One rook trade and two rook trades are different decisions.

17. Decision Framework

Rook Trade Decisions

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only after naming the favorable feature that survives the recapture.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Forecast the king activity, pawn targets, files, majorities, and minor-piece quality that survive simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible choices; move efficiently only in a position you truly recognize.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: One rook trade and two rook trades are different decisions.

18. Convert a Small Edge



ENDGAMES AND CONVERSION

READ THE POSITION

Technical play follows restriction, improvement, a second weakness, penetration, and collection.

PRIMARY PLAN

Do not collect a pawn if it releases every enemy piece.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. e3 Nbd7 6. Bd3 dxc4 7. Bxc4 b5 8. Bd3 a6 9. e4 c5 10. e5 cxd4 11. Nxb5

MEMORY RULE

Keep the position easy for your pieces and hard for theirs.

18. Decision Framework

Convert a Small Edge

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only after naming the favorable feature that survives the recapture.
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CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible choices; move efficiently only in a position you truly recognize.

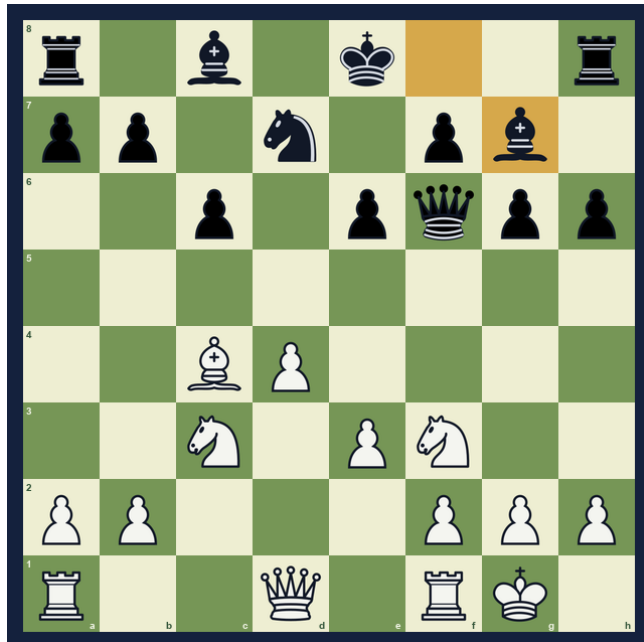
ACTIVE RECALL

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2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Keep the position easy for your pieces and hard for theirs.

19. Defend the Inferior Ending



ENDGAMES AND CONVERSION

READ THE POSITION

Active resistance creates checks, pawn races, and practical decisions.

PRIMARY PLAN

Seek activity and a forcing target instead of passive pawn defense.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. Bg5 h6 6. Bxf6 Qxf6 7. e3 Nd7 8. Bd3 dxc4 9. Bxc4 g6 10. O-O Bg7

MEMORY RULE

Counterplay is the defender's currency.

19. Decision Framework

Defend the Inferior Ending

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only after naming the favorable feature that survives the recapture.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Forecast the king activity, pawn targets, files, majorities, and minor-piece quality that survive simplification.
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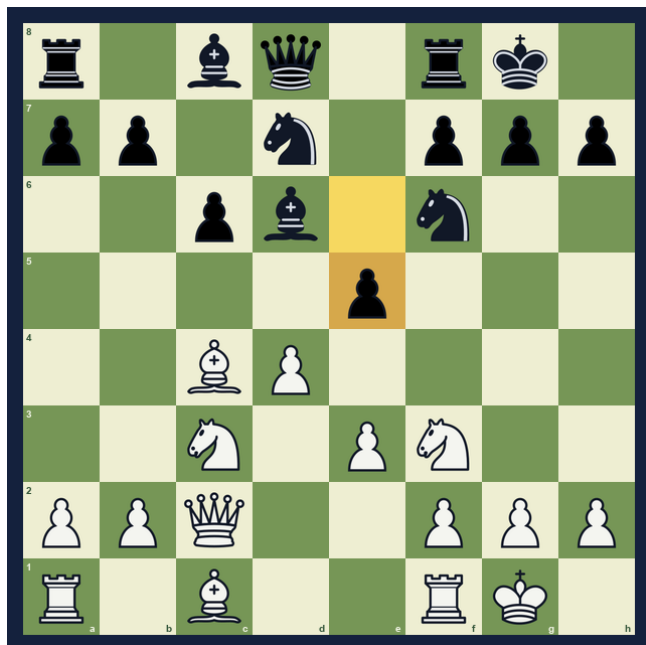
ACTIVE RECALL

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2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Counterplay is the defender's currency.

20. The Simplification Test



ENDGAMES AND CONVERSION

READ THE POSITION

A trade is favorable only when the surviving structure, piece, or king remains better.

PRIMARY PLAN

Name the exact advantage that exists after the recapture.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. e3 Nbd7 6. Qc2 Bd6 7. Bd3 O-O 8. O-O dxc4 9. Bxc4 e5

MEMORY RULE

If you cannot name what survives, do not simplify automatically.

20. Decision Framework

The Simplification Test

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only after naming the favorable feature that survives the recapture.
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4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: If you cannot name what survives, do not simplify automatically.

Course Completion Test

Choose ten chapters at random. Rebuild each reference position, name both sides' plans, identify the critical break, and state the trade filter without reopening the chapter.

Score one point for the structure, one for your plan, one for counterplay, one for the break, and one for the memory rule. Forty out of fifty means the knowledge is usable; below forty means retrieval practice should continue.

FINAL PRINCIPLE

A course is complete when its ideas appear in your decisions, not when its pages have been read.